

ONLINE SHOPPING

THE PERILS AND PIT-FALLS OF ONLINE SHOPPING

Online shopping can be one of the most convenient ways of getting your materialistic fixations, but sometimes, things go wrong and HOW! Here's a quick guide to avoiding such fiascos.

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The online shopping space has been a booming concept, but it's only recently been catching on in India, with sites like Flipkart and Snapdeal at the helm of this new movement. However, just as with all things that become big, they often tend to become too big for their shoes. Lately, the amount of horror stories we've heard from our readers regarding their experiences with many online portals has been alarming, to say the least.

The problem seems to be a growing one. Untimely deliveries, cancelled orders, missed deals. The online retail business is definitely going through a paradigm shift and with so many players not coming into the market, one must wonder why the competition hasn't been spurred to increase their quality of service? Maybe somewhere we've become a little too resigned to the whole "this is just how things are" mentality. For those of

you who aren't so passive, here's how you can maximize the joy of online shopping. We reached out to not just our readers, but also some online retailers to truly understand where the potential problems could lie and how you, as a buyer, could work around them.

Before Buying

Pick the right marketplace:

As of now there are a number of websites that have established themselves as key players in the business. Sites like Amazon, eBay, Flipkart, Snapdeal and HomeShop18 have established themselves as reputed marketplaces, amongst others, and we strongly recommend in dealing with only known brands. The reason for such an endorsement is the fact that their brand has been built on excellent customer service, even though they there might be a few hiccups from time to time. However, their rate

of messing up will definitely be much lower than that of a "new-kid-on-the-block" site.

A good marketplace is one that allows for free expression of opinions regarding shopping experiences. If a marketplace only has positive feedback, then there is some form of favouritism going on there. Websites like Amazon India and eBay have built their reputations on completely uncensored feedback, which is what has helped many buyers from all over the world make decisive purchase decisions.

Remember it's a marketplace, not a retailer:

There was a time when some of the online sites were the sellers of the item in question, but that is no more the case, for the most part. Most e-commerce sites have now switched to a marketplace model, meaning they no longer stock the